

SRH University Heidelberg

Master's Thesis

Explainable AI for Image Classification: Revealing and Interpreting Model Memorization

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Begin: & 01. October 2025
End: & 01. April 2026

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0.1 Introduction

Over the past decade, Artificial Intelligence (AI) has been firmly established in our society widely adopted across various sectors by optimizing operations, supporting decision-making processes, and enhancing productivity through the reduction of operational inefficiencies [1] [AAES+23]. In healthcare, AI supports disease detection and diagnosis, and [2] [PF24] enables faster and more accurate medical interventions. In finance, AI is employed to detect fraud and manage customized financial services [3][OUM24], decide eligibility in loan approval. Law enforcement agencies utilize artificial intelligence to aid in decision making and crime prevention. [4] [SHZ+24], [5] [JMH24], while the automotive sector leverages AI for the development and operation of autonomous vehicles [6][CMC+24]. This widespread adoption is underscored by recent industry reports. According to McKinsey's "The state of AI in 2025: Agents, innovation, and transformation", 88% organizations now use AI in at least one business function, with generative AI important focus for many companies. The Artificial Intelligence Index Report indicates that, from 2019 to 2024 worldwide, the number of funded AI companies increased by 60%, meaning robust investment and innovation in the field. [7][MYCR25] Moreover, when observing the use of AI within the companies reveal more than threefold increase in the number of employees are adopting generative AI into their works when comparing with the previous year's [8] [MFP+25]Despite the substantial advancements and pervasive integration of AI, experts in this field are increasingly addressing critical questions : Should we trust blindly in these AI-generated predictions and results? Does AI support human-centered approaches? Can we evaluate the explainability and transparency of AI? Such inquiries highlighted, the inherent need for robust methodologies and frameworks for establishing AI ethics.[9] [DSHV25]. The need is crucial to overcome the problem of opacity in AI results, referred to as "black box". A powerful technique is deep learning, which uses multi-layered neural networks to process complex data, however, the intricate nature of these networks often causes their decision-making process to be opaque, which hinders the establishment of trust in AI systems. This opaqueness becomes particularly problematic in the fields of healthcare, finance, and autonomous systems, where decisions have a significant impact on human life.

Consequently, the demand for Explainable AI has urged us to enhance the transparency and interpretability inherent in complex AI models [10] [YWW+23]. Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) refers to the set of methods and techniques that aim to present AI systems' decisions and functionalities in a human-understandable manner. Specifically, in image classification tasks, the use of Explainable AI techniques has become the primary focus through auditing model behavior. Post-hoc approaches in XAI focus on methods to simplify decision making logic, that are not intrinsically understandable to human users.[12] [ZWK25] These techniques, most notably Saliency Maps and Attribution Methods, aim to focus attention on the specific pixels or spatial regions that triggered a classification such as identifying the texture of a lesion in a medical scan, spatial sequence in biopsy resolution which allows to identify the risk factor in pregnancy or the facial recognition from images or video footage, or the shape of a pedestrian in autonomous driving.

However, despite their visual appeal, there is a growing consensus that many existing XAI methods fail to meet expectations, generally due to the technical limitations or lack of human-centered design.[11] [BLL+25] A preliminary study conducted using the CIFAR-10 dataset and the LIME (Local Interpretable Model-agnostic Explanations) explainer, anomalous explanation patterns were observed. Precisely, the explainer highlighted obscured local areas, where the areas are not relevant features of the objects themselves. This anomaly influenced class predictions, suggesting that the model was not performing generalized feature extraction but memorizing specific, irrelevant pixel-level artifacts from the training data.

Such observations address the lack of underlying memorization phenomena , where models utilize superficial correlations in the training data instead of learning robust representations. This behavior stress concerns about the faithfulness of post-hoc explanations, and their ability reflect model reasoning.

Consequently, this thesis seeks a bridge this gap by investigating the extent to which model memorization results in a misleading post-hoc explanations, using these observed anomalies as a baseline, extending this baseline with different post-hoc explanation methods to develop more faithful auditing frameworks for image classification models.

Figure 1 shows the overall structure of this thesis.

This thesis is organized as follows:

– Chapter 1: Introduction introduces the fundamental questions regarding the necessity of Explainable AI (XAI), the reliability of these systems in critical sectors, and the specific impact of model memorization on the fidelity of XAI outputs.

– Chapter 2: Literature Review and Background After a deep understanding and research on the context, 'Literature Review and Background' section proceed in detail with relevant articles related Image Classification, Explainable AI, Memorization Phenomenon.

– Chapter 3: Methodology section, provides detailed mathematical approach of explainable ai techniques, and CNN architecture that will be used in Implementation

– Chapter 4: Implementation and Structure section, provides the implementation process of the thesis which will introduced in appendix.

– Chapter 5: Evaluation and Results section evaluates the implementation results.

– Chapter 6: Conclusion and Future Work Finally, the whole project is concluded, and the future works are provided in section 'Conclusion and Future Work'.

0.2 Literature Review and Background

0.2.1 Foundations of Image Classification and Deep Learning

Image Classification

Image Classification is a categorization and labeling process by mapping high dimensional pixels data to a pre-defined set of discrete classes. For decades, researchers have developed advanced classification models due to the increasing complexity in image analysis, making it critical to improve classification accuracy and reduce labor force. CNN (Convolutional Neural networks) -based approaches have significantly advanced in the field of computer vision, especially in image classification tasks, their hierarchical feature extraction mechanism, and spatially invariant filters to efficiently learn robust features of an input image. The evolution of CNN architectures has marked a significant shift from shallow architectures to deep networks due to the evaluation of increasing complexity of datasets. In early breakthrough, AlexNet is a foundational architecture that utilises GPU(Graphical Processing Unit), and significantly improved the architecture of previous convolutional neural networks using multiple layers , dropout , ReLU activation function which mitigates the vanishing gradient problem, and data augmentation to prevent overfitting. Subsequently in GoogleNet, the inception module offers a method to introduce parallel convolutional layers with varying filter sizes, which allows the network to capture features with different scales while maintaining computational efficiency .(Noor & Ige, 2024) .VGGNet , on the other hand, focus on the principle of using convolutional layers with small 3X3 filters , demonstrating that increasing the network depth could improve feature extraction capabilities. In contrast to VGGNet's emphasis on depth , in 2015 at the ILSVRC (Image Net Large Scale Visual Recognition Challenge) , ResNet was introduced with residual connections, allowing deeper networks to be trained effectively by creating skip connections allows the features learned in the previous layers to be directly reused in the upcoming layers that facilitate the backpropagation. Recent advancements in CNN Architecture the vanishing gradient problem, diminishing feature reuse while elevate the classification error by improving the feature learning . DenseNet was introduced in 2016, follows the same methodology as ResNet,utilizing residual connections between layers . However, DenseNet establishes a dense block where it consists multiple convolution functions followed by batch normalization, ReLU activation function ,and 3x3 convolution ,maximizes the information flow ,feature reuse and preserves the feedforward nature of the network. [MNI25]. ResNeXt addresses the issue of diminishing feature reuse by capturing more efficient and diverse features . While traditional networks improve performance by increasing the depth, often at the cost of computational efficiency, ResNeXt introduces a third dimension : Cardinality. By integrating residual connections of ResNet with the parallel path methodology of Inception modules, ResNeXt manages complex interactions without a computational explosion.

pre-trained cnn models with ImageNet dataset: [MNI25]

Collectively, these innovations illustrate clear evolutionary progression in CNN design, each share common underlying principles that govern how convolutional neural networks function with visual information. Understanding these fundamental concepts is essential for further analysis on memorization phenomenon in CNN architectures.

Brief Overview of CNN(Convolutional Neural Network) Components

The Convolutional Neural Network is a feedforward neural network designed to automatically extract hierarchical features from input data with convolutional structures .Unlike traditional feature extraction methods, CNN does not require manual feature engineering, as learning complex features hierarchically.

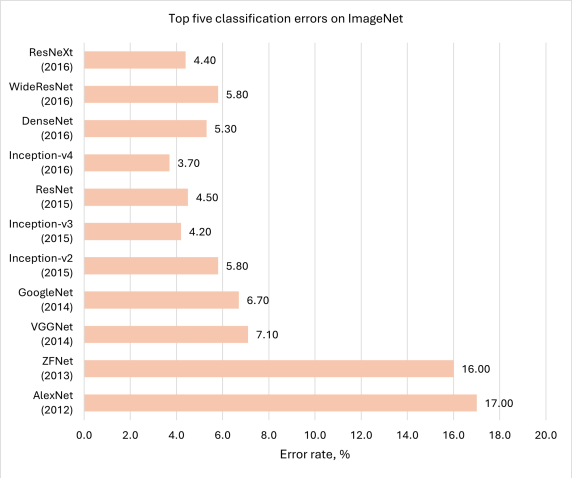


Figure 1: The classification error comparison between pre-trained models with ImageNet dataset

A key characteristic of CNNs is their hierarchical learning mechanism. Early convolutional layers capture low-level visual patterns such as edges, corners, and textures, while deeper layers can progressively integrate this low-level information into more complex, abstract representations, including object parts and semantic concepts. This hierarchical learning enables CNNs to achieve remarkable performance in various computer vision tasks, including image classification, object detection, and semantic segmentation [13] [Fel25]. Additionally, the specialized structure of CNN, which includes convolutional layers, pooling layers, and fully connected layers, facilitates parameter sharing and reduces the total number of learnable parameters, making them efficient for processing high-dimensional image data [14][BJY+18], [15][GNKN23].

The transition from traditional structure to modern structural innovations has empowered CNNs with higher dimensional capacity. While these advancements, such as non-linear activations , residual learning , more layered structure, enable the model to capture intricate details.

Despite the elevated structure, and high classification accuracy, the inherent opaqueness of these complex models often limits their interpretability, making it challenging to understand the underlying reasons for their predictions [16][IS23]. This lack of transparency becomes particularly critical in image classification tasks, where high accuracy may mask memorization effects.

Consequently, understanding of CNNs encode and utilize learned features requires the use of explainable artificial intelligence (XAI) techniques, which aim to reveal and interpret the internal representations and decision making mechanisms of deep neural networks.

Feature Extraction vs. Classification

The architecture of a Convolutional Neural Network is primarily characterized by two stages : feature extraction and classification. Understanding the distinction between these two stages is crucial for evaluating the reason behind the irrelevant pixel-level artifacts identified in image classification tasks.

The Role of Feature Extraction

Theorem 0.2.1 *The convolution of an input x with a filter w, parameterized by Q = w,b, for a single channel, is defined as:* $(x \otimes w)_{i,j} = \sum_m \sum_n x_{m,n}.w_{i-m,j-n} + b$ *where* $\otimes$ *denotes the convolution operation. For*

multichannel inputs, this operation is performed independently for each channel and summed to produce a single output.

The feature extraction stage, comprising convolutional and pooling layers, performs a hierarchical decomposition of a raw data input into more abstract and semantically meaningful representations. Convolutional layers, by applying filters to the input image, generate a feature map . This feature map highlights the specific patterns and features, such as edges, corners , and textures, present in the image [16][FWN21]. Subsequently, pooling layers facilitates the reduction of dimensionality through down sampling. This reduction helps to reduce complexity by retaining the most salient features, while also enhancing the model's robustness to spatial variations and minor distortions in the input [13][Fel25].

The Role of Classification

Following the feature extraction stage, fully connected layers also known as multilayer perceptrons take the flattened output of the feature extraction to perform a global synthesis of the learned patterns. Each neuron in these layers is connected to every activation in the previous layer, performing a linear transformation followed by a non-linear activation function.

Mathematically, this operation is expressed as :

Theorem 0.2.2 $y_i = \sigma(Wx + b)$ *where x denotes the input vector, W denotes the weight matrix, b is the bias term, and* σ *is the non-linear activation function.*

This process functions as a decision-maker, integrating high dimensional feature vectors into specific semantic labels to produce the final classification. While convolutional layers focus on local spatial hierarchies, the fully connected layers interpret these features globally to determine the final probability distribution of the classes.

0.2.2 The Taxonomy of Explainable AI in Image Classification

This section establishes a comprehensive taxonomy of Explainable Artificial Intelligence and delves into mathematical foundations . The explorations focus on the categorization of XAI methods ante-hoc versus post-hoc, global versus local, and model-specific versus model-agnostic techniques, while integrating the underlying mathematical principles that govern their interpretability [Fer23, SAS25, SF23]. The essential focus is directed towards post-hoc techniques, given their substantial used in giving explanations in complex, black-box models. Understanding the post-hoc techniques ,generally fall into Attribution Methods and Model-Agnostic Local Explanations, leverage the understanding of the phenomenon of Memorization .

Following flowchart illustrates the taxonomy of explainable ai in this thesis.

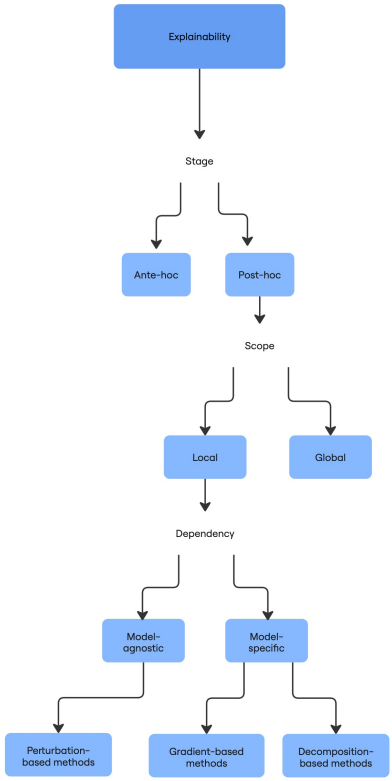


Figure 2: The flowchart of taxonomy explanation

The Categorization by Stage

XAI methods can also be described based on the stage of interpretability. This categorisation is derived at which the explanation is generated: during the model design (ante-hoc) or after the model has been trained (post-hoc).

Ante-hoc Interpretability Ante-hoc Interpretability are known as intrinsic explainability, transparent or glass-box models, which are inherently interpretable because of their uncomplicated structure.(Retzlaff et al., 2024) This simpler structure allows direct comprehension of internal decision making process . Despite their intrinsic interpretability of ante-hoc approaches, the predictive power of such models often diminishes with increasing complexity of the underlying features and data, specifically in high dimensional image processing tasks, where the straightforward linear relationships and decision trees struggle to capture complex patterns in image pixel regions.

Post-hoc Interpretability Contradictory to ante-hoc methods, post-hoc interpretability refers to the techniques which analyse and interpret the decision-making process of a trained model after it has made predictions, providing explanations how the model arrived at its outputs. This approach focuses on the need to

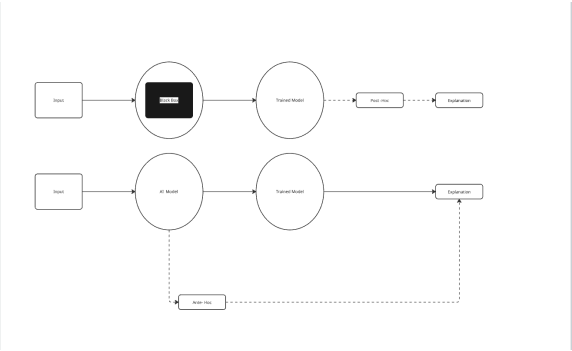


Figure 3: Different Interpretability Approach in Deep Learning Model

simplify the decision logic of black-box models to human friendly forms.

In high-dimensional domains such as image classification, achieving high level of prediction performance is often prioritized over transparency. Additionally, the unknown relationships and intricate patterns that constrained in simpler models necessitate the use of post-hoc approaches that can reveal the hidden complexities. For this reason, post-hoc methods are indispensable for trustworthy deployment of deep learning systems.

Post-hoc techniques are commonly divided into two important categories : Model Agnostic, and Model Specific methods.

The Categorization by Scope

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The categorisation on the basis of Scope mainly involves in two directions: global explanations, and local explanations.

Global Explainability Global Explainability aims to provide global understanding of a model's overall logic, revealing the general relationships between features and the model's predictions overall the entire dataset (Agrawal & Sharma, 2024). An explanation is considered as global if the explanator othen than why of local explanations, provides also how a decision is made.(Schwalbe & Finzel, 2021)

(Feature Importance, Partial Dependence Plots, and Surrogate Models are common techniques employed for global interpretability, offering insights into the average behavior of a model across its entire input space (Černevičienė & Kabašinskas, 2024; Höhl et al., 2024). This approach allows for comprehension of the model's general tendencies and the influence of features on its global output (Khan et al., 2024).)

Local Explainability Conversely, Local Explainability focuses on the reasoning behind a specific prediction for a single data instance, addressing how individual features contribute to the prediction for a particular input. This distinction is crucial for tailoring XAI methods to specific user needs and tasks. Specifically in image classification tasks, understanding why a model classifies a particular image , requires localised explanations that highlight specific regions or features within that individual image contributes to the decision .

Local Post-hoc Interpretation Techniques

Model-agnostic techniques Regardless of the architecture of the model, these methods aim to explain the decision making process of the model flexible and applicable across diverse machine learning models.(Devireddy, 2025; Ramachandram et al., 2025)This independence enables a universal framework, by simultaneously analysing the inputs and outputs without gaining model insights such as weights or parameters. However, such methods typically approximate the model locally or globally, which may limit their faithfulness.

Perturbation-based methods Perturbation-based methods operate by systematically perturbing parts of the input image and observing the corresponding changes of perturbed parts in the model's predictions.This approach is model-agnostic, as it does not rely on the internal architecture of the model, and can therefore be applied across wide range of models . As they rely on observing changes in the model's output in response to input perturbations, can be performed in black-box settings. Since the information in images is typically highly correlated across neighbouring pixels, perturbing individual pixels is unlikely to influence on the prediction.(Pihlgren & Främling, 2024). Instead, the input image is commonly perturbed at the level of segmented regions.Each segmented regions is then sampled with respect on the predefined sampling strategy that determines which regions should be perturbed or occluded. Based on this strategy, multiple perturbed instances are generated , while the remaining regions are kept unchanged. Each perturbed segment is then passed through the trained model, and resulting in a measure of the prediction change with respect to the original output. Based on these prediction differences, an attribution score is assigned to each region, reflecting its relative importance in the model's prediction alterations. Finally, these scores are aggregated to generate a saliency map, a visual explanation that highlights influential regions of the image.

Representative perturbation-based methods include LIME, Kernel SHAP which all utilize perturbation by leveraging individual features in a model.

Model specific techniques Conversely, model specific techniques leverage the internal structure of the AI model or algorithm, to provide more insightful and effective explanations such as learned parameters or gradients . These methods often tailored to specific machine learning models, especially deep learning models. While this model-specific explanation techniques can yield more precise and architecture dependent explanations , their applicability into practice if often limited, this incapability restricts their acceptance into mainstream research of XAI methods.(Hassija et al., 2023). Additionally, this approach is inherently applicable in Convolutional Neural Networks, where convolutional layers , feature maps, and gradients are directly utilise to highlight specific regions of the input image contribute most to a prediction.

Gradient-based methods Gradient-based methods, are widely used in convolutional neural networks, assume that the parameters of the model are accessible.These techniques employ forward and backward pass to estimate the influence of each input pixel respect with the original output. During the forward-pass ,the input image is passed through a deep neural network to generate a prediction score for a specific class. In the subsequent backward step, instead of adjusting weights , the gradient of the output score using back-propagation with respect to the input pixels is computed. This gradient then indicates the sensitivity of prediction to slight changes in each pixel, thereby highlighting which features the model is important related to model's prediction.

Saliency Maps, Grad-Cam, and Integrated Gradients are commonly used techniques under the gradient-based methods .

Decomposition-based methods Decomposition-based techniques decompose the model output layer by layer into different features and showing the contribution of each input feature relevance towards the final prediction. While gradient-based approaches that measure the sensitivity of the output to small changes in input features, decomposition-methods focus on highly localised features which results in more precise attributions.

A prominent example is Layer-wise Relevance Propagation (LRP), which systematically redistributes the prediction score to the previous layer , based on specific LRP rules to assign a relevance score to each input feature.

0.2.3 The Phenomenon of Memorization

Memorization is a phenomenon where machine learning models, particulary deep neural netwokrs, learn to remember specific training examples instead of learning patterns that generaliye well to unseen data. This phenomenon often occcurs when models are overfitted to the training data, especially when dta set is small and consists noisy or irrelevant features. In hidden layers of neural networks,

Generalization and Memorization Tradeoff

Memorization Strategies in Convolutional Neural Networks

0.2.4 Faithfulness and Plausibility of Explainable AI

0.3 Methodology

0.4 Implementation and Structure

0.5 Evaluation and Results

0.6 Conclusion and Future Work

0.7 Appendix

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